

The Expression of Strong Definiteness in Code-switched Context

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Introduction and Background: Both definite noun phrases (e.g. the boy) and demonstrative noun phrases (e.g. that boy) can be used anaphorically, i.e. to refer back to previously mentioned discourse referents; recent work has been investigating the differing pragmatic constraints between anaphoric definites and demonstratives, finding crosslinguistic stability in these constraints across many languages including English, Turkish, Bangla, and German (Saha, Sag, Davidson 2023, Saha 2023, Saha and Davidson 2024), but noting Mandarin as an outlier in the semantics of its demonstrative (Saha, Sag, Cui, and Davidson 2024). In this work we leverage these differences between Mandarin and English demonstratives to understand constraints on code-switching within anaphoric noun phrases. This study aims to a) test the predictions of the matrix language framework (Myers-Scotten, 1993), and b) investigate the interaction between code-switching and the expression of anaphoricity and definiteness crosslinguistically.

Methodology: We conducted two studies, each with contexts plus paired continuations in the design of Saha et al. 2023. The first had Mandarin as the matrix language, with only the nominal code-switched into English (Mandarin demonstrative noun phrase or Mandarin bare noun phrase), the other had English as the matrix language with only nominals code-switched into Mandarin (English definite noun phrase or English demonstrative). Switched nominals were extracted from SEAME corpus and selected to motivate natural code-switching, i.e. (那个 quiz ‘that quiz’, that 唢呐, ‘that suona’). Results: Overall, we observe very similar patterns to that found in monolingual Mandarin and English contexts, supporting the MLF. The Mandarin demonstrative noun phrases is preferred over bare noun phrases in Mandarin-English code-switching while the English definite noun phrases is rated more acceptable than the demonstrative in English-Mandarin code-switching. Additionally, a global cognitive code-switching cost might be responsible for the overall lower acceptability rates in code-switched context than in monolingual context.